But in the media clash of 2014, television had competition too—the war in cyberspace, especially social media, was about to change the rules of old-style debates and political jousts. It was to prove, in many ways, the ultimate triumph of not just an individual, but the idea of ‘Team Modi’.

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Narendra Modi joined Facebook and Twitter in late 2009. It wasn’t the kind of spectacular big-bang entry that the BJP leader normally likes. For the first two years, Modi didn’t set the popular social networking sites on fire. In 2011, he still had barely 6 lakh followers on his Facebook page. His Twitter following, too, was well behind that of someone like Shashi Tharoor’s, who was really the first Indian politician to join the Twitterati.

By the time the elections were over in May, Modi had a staggering 1.5 million ‘likes’ on his Facebook page, second only to US President Obama in terms of his fan following. Through 2014, Modi had, according to a Facebook spokesperson, the fastest growing page of any politician worldwide. ‘Facebook was our mother site which drove our social media campaign,’ says a Modi aide. Several individuals set up their own Modi Facebook pages—for example, a volunteer called Vikas Pandey set up an ‘I support Modi’ page, another had a ‘NaMo for PM’ page, all of which became aggregators to the Modi social media machine.

On Twitter, too, the Modi base kept increasing. By the time the elections were done and dusted, Modi had 4.27 million Twitter followers. According to Twitter India, five of the top ten election tweets had been sent from Modi’s account. They included a selfie with his mother and a victory tweet.

Contrast it with Rahul Gandhi. The Congress’s ‘youth’ talisman wasn’t even on the world’s two most popular sites for youth interactivity. I asked a Congress social media cell member why. ‘You know, Rahulji doesn’t like impersonal communication. If he is to get on Twitter, he would like to handle his account himself and, frankly, he doesn’t have the time for it,’ was the explanation I was given.